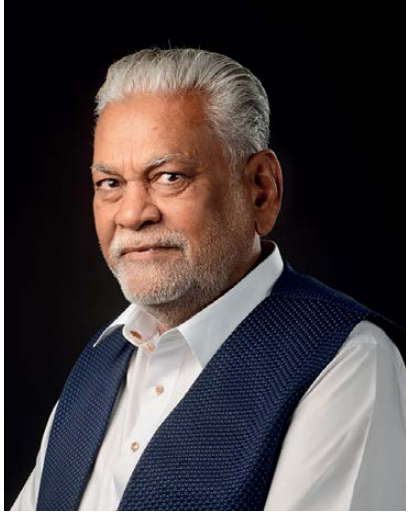
PARSHOTTAM RUPALA, *69* ▶

| BJP | *Rajkot, Gujarat*

The maharajas had given their daughters to foreign rulers and the British"—it was a potentially well-meaning remark with republican values from the Modi cabinet minister with a perch in the Upper House since 2016. But it stirred up a hornet's nest and this Amreli native's foray into Rajkot became one of the events of the 2024 campaign—whose Richter reading was felt far beyond Saurashtra or even Gujarat. Though Rajput ire was not quite salved by many apologies, the BJP persisted with the veteran and, among other factors, a Patidar counter-mobilisation lifted him to safety.



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

◀ PIYUSH GOYAL, *60*

| BJP | *Mumbai North, Maharashtra*

When Piyush Goyal was dispatched to this "safest seat" to seek a popular mandate for the first time, he wasn't exactly being parachuted into alien territory. His father Ved Prakash Goyal—industrialist, long-time BJP treasurer and Union minister under A.B. Vajpayee—was a naturalised citizen in these parts, even a Rajya Sabha MP from Maharashtra. His mother Chandrakanta Goyal was entrenched deeper in Mumbai—corporator from Sion and a three-time Matunga MLA. The Union minister didn't quite maintain the party's post-2014 vote share of 70-plus per cent in the seat, but held off the INDIA tide sweeping the state with a 65.6 per cent catch.



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR



▲ VIVEK THAKUR, *54*

| BJP | *Nawada, Bihar*

The son of former Union minister C.P. Thakur, he was pretty much bequeathed with a pre-scripted political journey that began with the BJP's youth wing and now arrives at the Hall of the Elect—after a Rajya Sabha detour from 2020. A degree in political science from Delhi University's Kirori Mal College, one in law, and another from the Indian Institute of Foreign Trade in Delhi, frame the kind of savvy that took him to membership of the commerce ministry's consultative committee. Party colleagues too say it's not for nothing that he's feted as one of the "most educated MPs from Bihar", calling him a widely-read person with a fresh, progressive perspective.



▲ RUDRA NARAYAN PANY, *65*

| BJP | *Dhenkanal, Odisha*

Another former Rajya Sabha member (2004-12), he'd never been an elected MP before—but not for want of trying. What sets Pany apart is that his debut entry to the House of the People comes on the seventh attempt! As a dyed-in-the-wool saffronwala even when the colour wasn't so popular in Odisha, he contested unsuccessfully from Dhenkanal in 1991, 1996, 1999 (as an Independent), 2009, 2014 and 2019. His perseverance must have impressed the BJP's Chanakyas enough to hand him another ticket—and he rode the wave.

–Dhaval S. Kulkarni, Jumana Shah, Arkamoy Datta Majumdar and Amitabh Srivastava